

LACERTA

THE LIZARD

A SMALL, OBSCURE CONSTELLATION, LACERTA HAS A ZIGZAG PATTERN THAT RESEMBLES A SCURRYING LIZARD. IT LIES IN THE NORTHERN PATH OF THE MILKY WAY, SANDWICHED BETWEEN THE CONSTELLATIONS OF ANDROMEDA AND CYGNUS. ITS MAIN STARS ARE IN THE REPTILE’S HEAD.

Lacerta was named in 1687 when the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius first described it. It was one of 11 new constellations he devised to fill gaps in the northern sky; seven of these are still in use today. Lacerta’s stars are faint and none have names, but it has been the site of occasional nova explosions. Among the constellation’s dense

Milky Way star clouds are few significant deep-sky objects. However, one object of note is BL Lacertae, the prototype of a strange class of galaxy with active nuclei, known as B Lac objects or blazars. These are a type of quasar that emit energetic jets directly toward Earth, giving them the appearance of a star.

KEY DATA

Size ranking	68
Brightest stars	Alpha (α) 3.8, 1 Lacertae 4.1
Genitive	Lacertae
Abbreviation	Lac
Highest in sky at 10pm	September–October
Fully visible	90°N–33°S



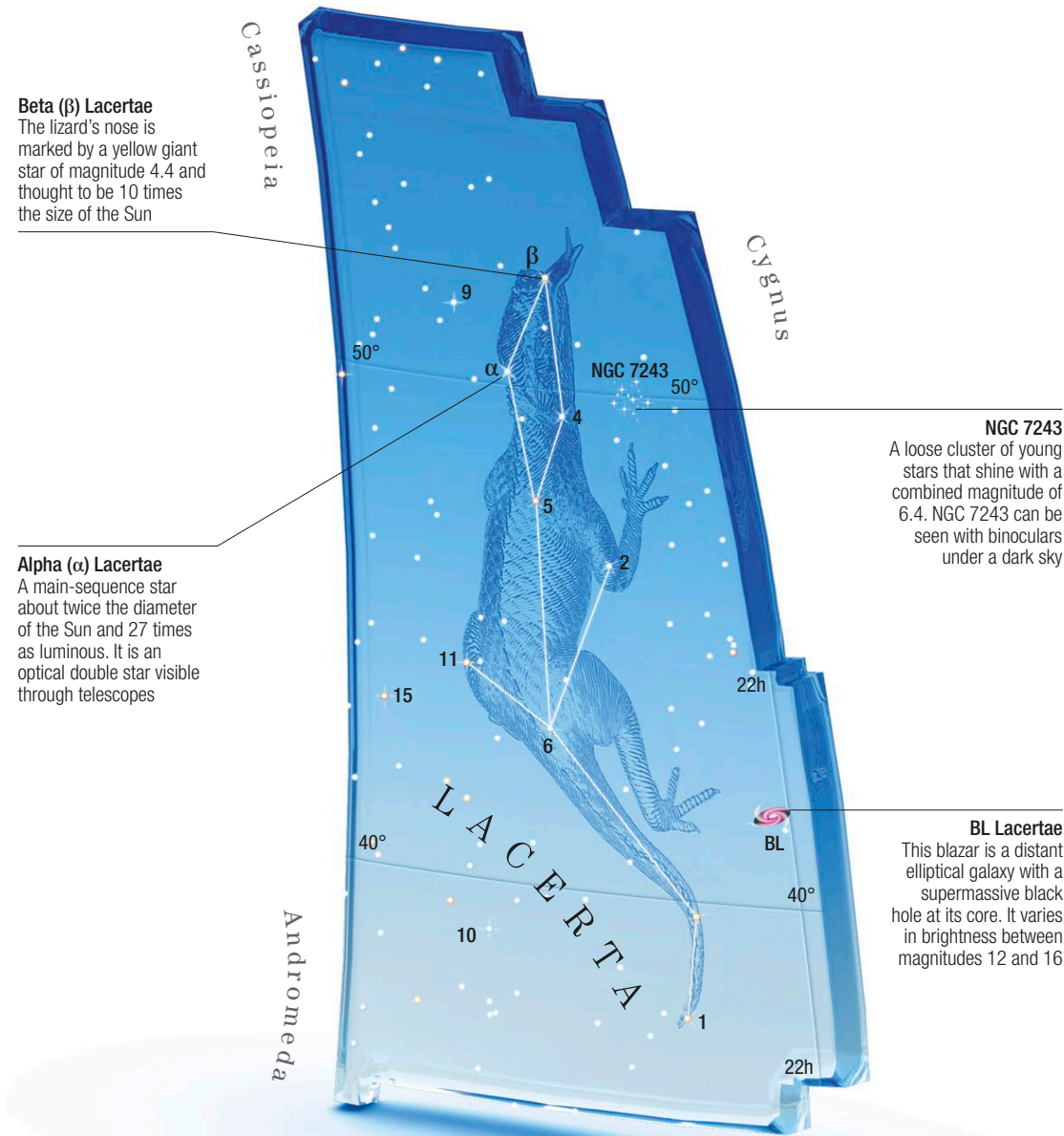
CHART 3

MAIN STARS

Alpha (α) Lacertae Blue-white main-sequence star
☼ 3.8 ↔ 103 light-years
Beta (β) Lacertae Yellow giant
☼ 4.4 ↔ 170 light-years
1 Lacertae Orange giant
☼ 4.1 ↔ 621 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 7243 Open star cluster
BL Lacertae Blazar and the prototype of B Lac objects



△ **NGC 7243**
This group of blue-white stars is about 2,800 light-years away. The young blue-white stars stand out against a rich starfield of yellow and red stars. Seen through a small telescope, there are about 120 stars spread across an area equal to that of the Full Moon. Their loose scattering has made it uncertain whether or not they form a true star cluster.